

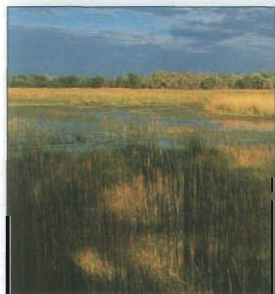
AFRICA



THE SECOND LARGEST CONTINENT after Asia, Africa is dominated in the north by the vast Sahara Desert and in the east by the Great Rift Valley. A belt of rainforest lies along the Equator, and grasslands provide grazing for herds of wild animals. Africa is home to many different peoples, each with their own distinctive languages and customs. Islam and Christianity are widespread, but many Africans adhere to their own traditional beliefs.

Physical features

Most of Africa is a high plateau covered with deserts, lush rainforests, and dry grasslands. It is crossed by rivers, which bring water to dry regions and provide communications. Although they lie on the Equator, the high peaks in the east are snow-capped all year. Africa has several volcanoes.



Okavango Delta

Many rivers end in deltas at the sea, but the Okavango River in southern Africa has a delta that forms a swamp in the Kalahari Desert. The Okavango rises in Angola and flows 974 km (605 miles) to Botswana, where its delta and swamps cover more than 22,000 sq km (8,500 sq miles).



Sahara

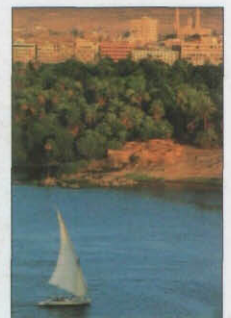
The world's largest desert, the Sahara, covers much of northwestern Africa. It has an area of 9,065,000 sq km (3,263,400 sq miles) and is rapidly expanding as land at its edges is overgrazed. With less than 100 mm (4 in) of rainfall every year and daytime temperatures of up to 50°C (122°F), only a few specially adapted plants and animals survive here.

River Nile

The Nile is the world's longest river. From its source in Lake Victoria, it flows 6,695 km (4,160 miles) north through Uganda, Sudan, and Egypt to the Mediterranean Sea. Africa's third longest river, the Niger, flows 4,180 km (2,597 miles) in a big loop through western Africa, ending in Nigeria in a delta bigger than that of the Nile.

Mountains rise from the Great Rift Valley.

River Nile at Aswan in Egypt



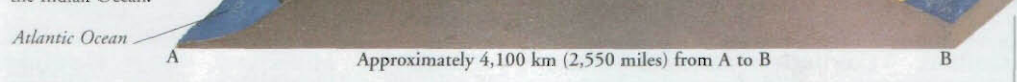
Simen Mountains, Ethiopia

Great Rift Valley

The mountains of Ethiopia are divided by the Great Rift Valley that stretches 6,000 km (3,750 miles) north from Mozambique, through east Africa and the Red Sea, into Syria. The valley is formed by massive cracks in the Earth's crust. It is up to 90 km (55 miles) wide, and in millions of years will eventually divide the African continent.

Cross-section through Africa

Africa rises sharply from the Atlantic Ocean up to about 1,000 m (3,280 ft) before dropping down into the marshes of the Zaire Basin. The Ruwenzori Mountains and Great Rift Valley lie to the east, and the plateau falls gently to the Indian Ocean.



AFRICA FACTS

AREA	30,335,000 sq km (11,712,434 sq miles)
POPULATION	783,800,000
NUMBER OF COUNTRIES	53
BIGGEST COUNTRY	Sudan
SMALLEST COUNTRY	Seychelles
HIGHEST POINT	Kilimanjaro (Tanzania) 5,895 m (19,341 ft)
LONGEST RIVER	Nile (Uganda/Sudan/Egypt) 6,695 km (4,160 miles)
BIGGEST LAKE	Lake Victoria (East Africa) 68,880 sq km (26,590 sq miles)